

RURAL CENTER REDI TRAINING

# Cross-Sector Collaboration

Sometimes the Only Lifeline to Economic Development

---

November 3, 2026

TODAY'S SPEAKER

# Anita Brown-Graham

---

- Gladys Hall Coates Distinguished Professor of Public Law and Government
- Associate Dean for Strategic Initiatives
- Director, nclIMPACT Initiative



# What Are Cross-Sector Collaboratives?

Addressing complex challenges too immense for any one organization or sector to solve alone.



## Diverse Expertise

Cross-sector collaboratives bring together nonprofit, for-profit, and government sectors.



## Shared Resources

They leverage shared information, resources, and capabilities to find solutions.



## Know the Landscape

Understanding who is doing what is crucial to moving the work forward.

# Foundational Principles



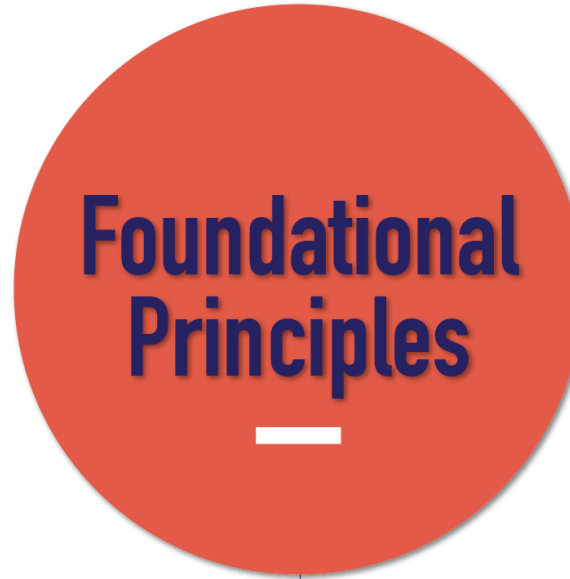
## Peer Learning

Collaboratives over-perform when they can learn about promising practices from others, work toward shared goals, and overcome common challenges together.



## Evidence-Based Action

Collaboratives choose actions that are primarily motivated by what is known to be effective while rigorously evaluating new and experimental approaches.



## Network of Networks

Collaboratives constantly build social capital by developing connections between individuals and organizations, increasing their capacity and available resources.

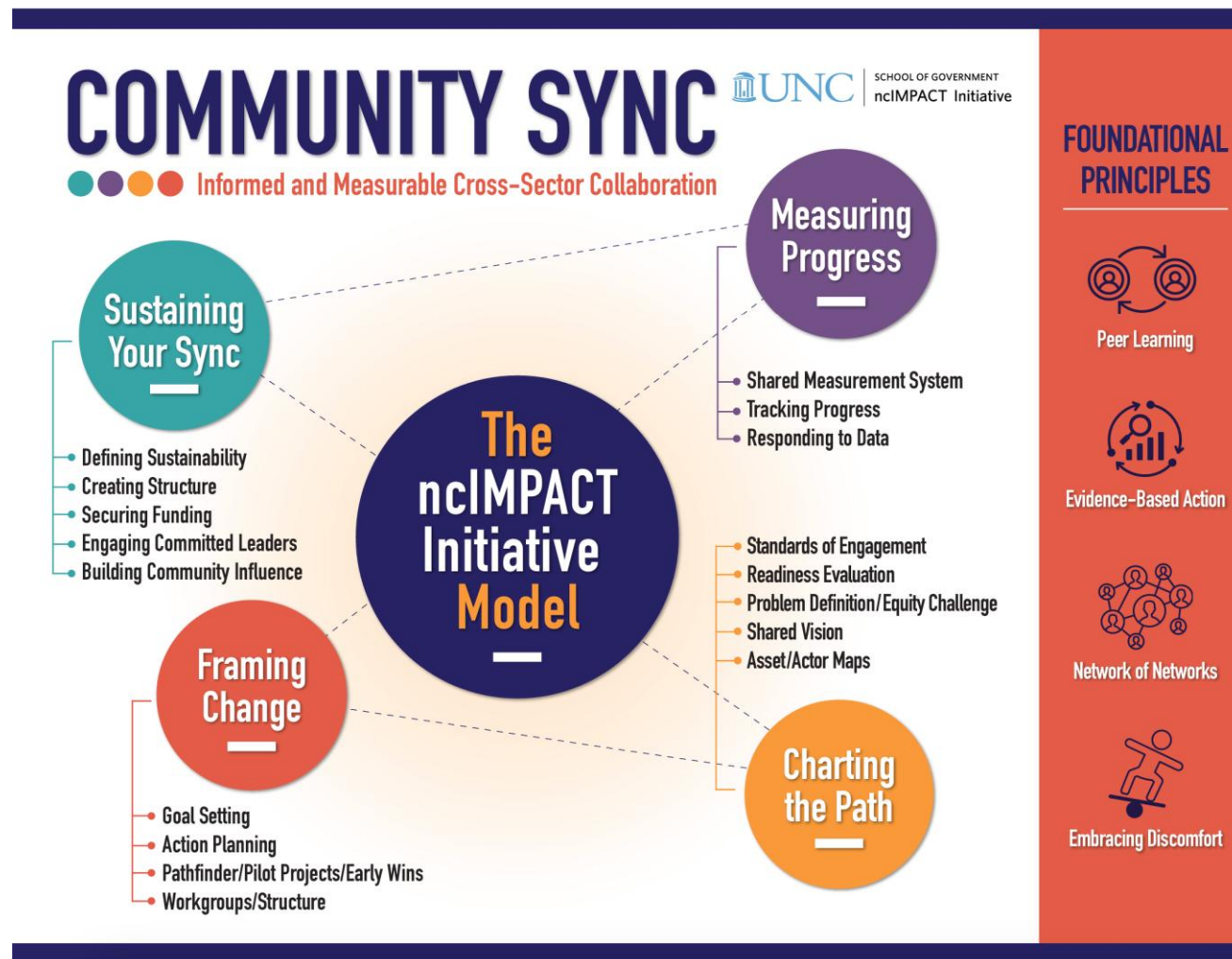


## Embracing Discomfort

Collaboratives recognize the challenge of working across organizations and sectors but value the opportunity to engage and learn from varied perspectives.

## The Model

50+ cross-sector collaboratives facilitated across North Carolina, refined into one evidence-based model — blending Collective Impact and Strategic Doing in a non-linear way, focused on what works for diverse stakeholders.



## THE COMMUNITY SYNC FRAMEWORK

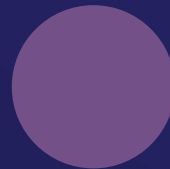
# Four Interconnected Components



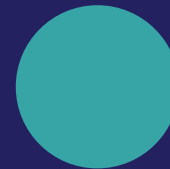
Charting  
the Path



Framing  
Change



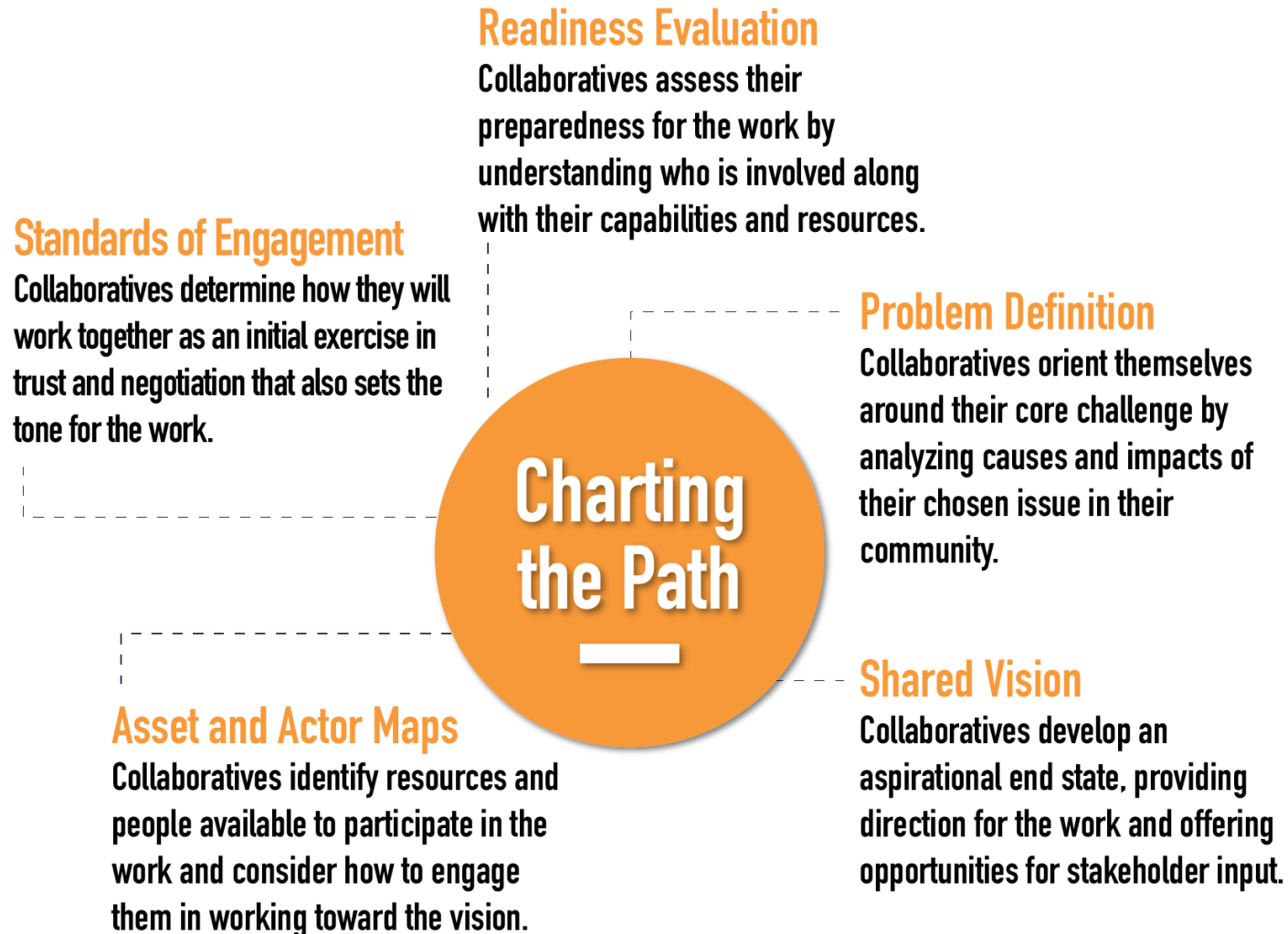
Measuring  
Progress



Sustaining  
Your Sync

This model emphasizes learning by doing — simultaneous planning and action.  
Early wins build confidence and momentum.

## The Community Sync Framework — Charting the Path





ON YOUR OWN, IN YOUR COMMUNITY

**An aging, inadequate housing stock that no longer meets current residents' needs or supports the businesses and talent we want to attract.**

Barriers to workforce recruitment

Fewer options to age in place

High costs & energy inefficiency

Undermined neighborhood stability

## Who's Missing from the Table?

Using the housing challenge, consider who would need to be part of a collaborative in your community that works on the issue.

1

### BRAINSTORM

2 MIN

Identify 3 people, organizations, or sectors that will be key to the success of a collaborative in your community.

2

### PRIORITIZE

1 MIN

Choose the ONE of those actors that will be difficult to engage. Why?

3

### MAKE THE CASE

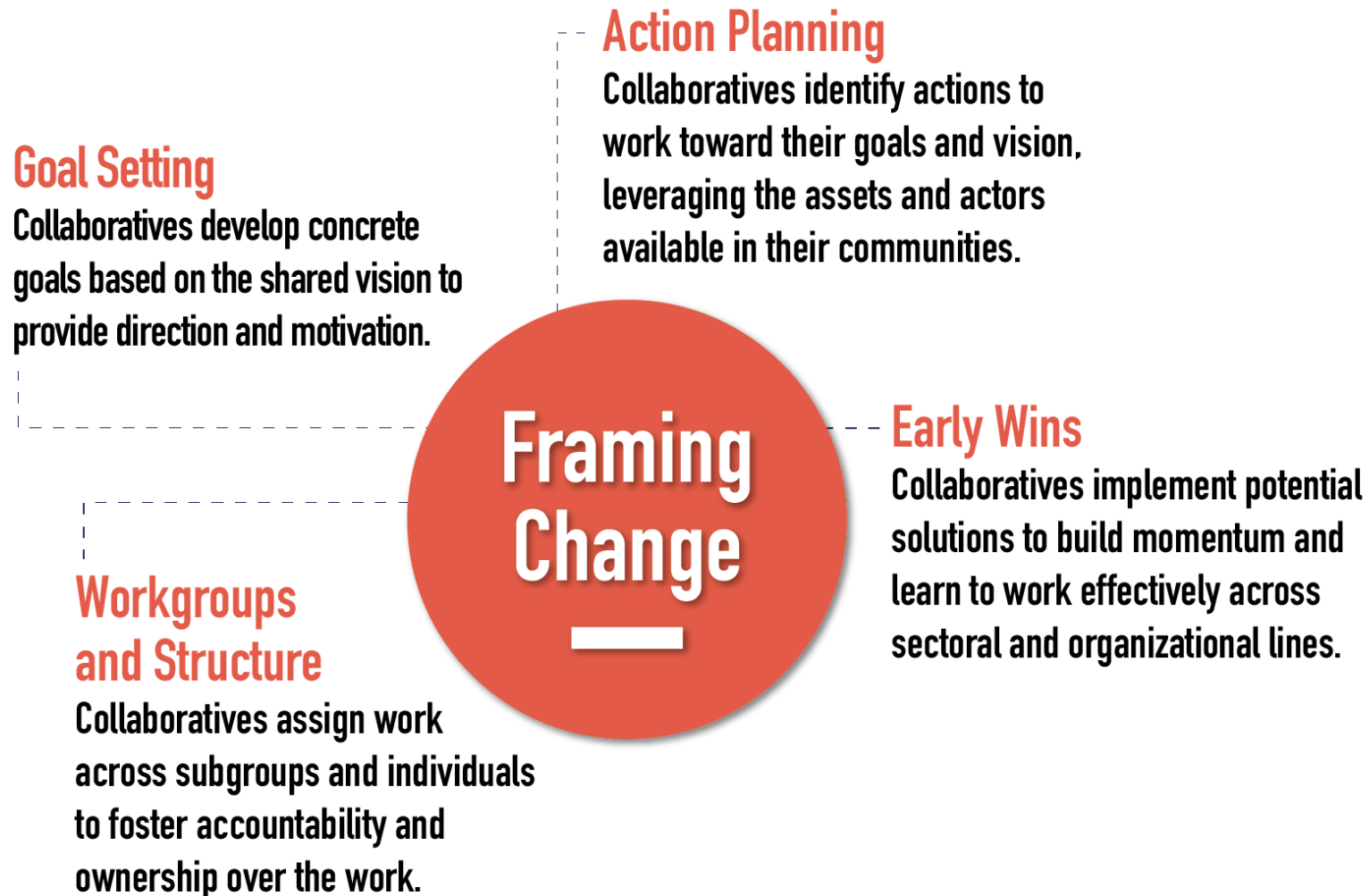
2 MIN

What does that actor contribute? What might motivate them to participate? Who could help bring them to the table?

### REPORT OUT

Whom did you choose — and why?

## The Community Sync Framework — Framing Change



## SCENARIO SETUP

# Get into Groups of Four

Your group has convened a cross-sector collaborative to develop comprehensive, coordinated strategies that transform local housing stock from a liability into an asset.



**Municipal & county  
government**



**Employers facing workforce  
housing challenges**



**Community development  
institutions**



**Nonprofits serving  
unhoused residents**



**Healthcare systems**



**Educational institutions**



**Utility providers**



**Neighborhood  
representatives**

**Note: There are currently no real estate developers in the community.**

## Turn the Challenge into a SMARTIE Goal

“Improve the community’s housing stock” gives us direction but isn’t yet an actionable goal.

### 1 CHOOSE A FOCUS — 2 minutes

What part of the housing challenge will your collaborative address?

### 2 DRAFT YOUR GOAL — 8 minutes

Make it:

Specific

Measurable

Ambitious

Realistic

Time-bound

Inclusive

Equitable

#### REPORT OUT

**Share your SMARTIE goal with the group.**

#### EXAMPLE

*By the end of 2027, increase participation in the annual county pie-eating contest, with at least one participant from every zip code in the county and free entry for anyone facing cost barriers.*

## The Community Sync Framework — Measuring Progress

### Shared Measurement System

Collaboratives develop a set of shared metrics for success to evaluate progress within teams and across the peer group.



## Measuring Progress

### Responding to Data

Collaboratives adjust their work based on metrics of progress, doing more of what has been effective and doing less of what has not.

### Tracking Progress

Collaboratives report on progress toward their goals to keep themselves accountable and celebrate successes.

## Create Shared Measures

Six months from now, your collaborative will review its progress toward your SMARTIE goal.

1

### BUILD YOUR DASHBOARD — 4 minutes

Choose 3 measures that, together, would give your collaborative a useful picture of progress toward your SMARTIE goal.

1 . \_\_\_\_\_ 2 . \_\_\_\_\_ 3 . \_\_\_\_\_

2

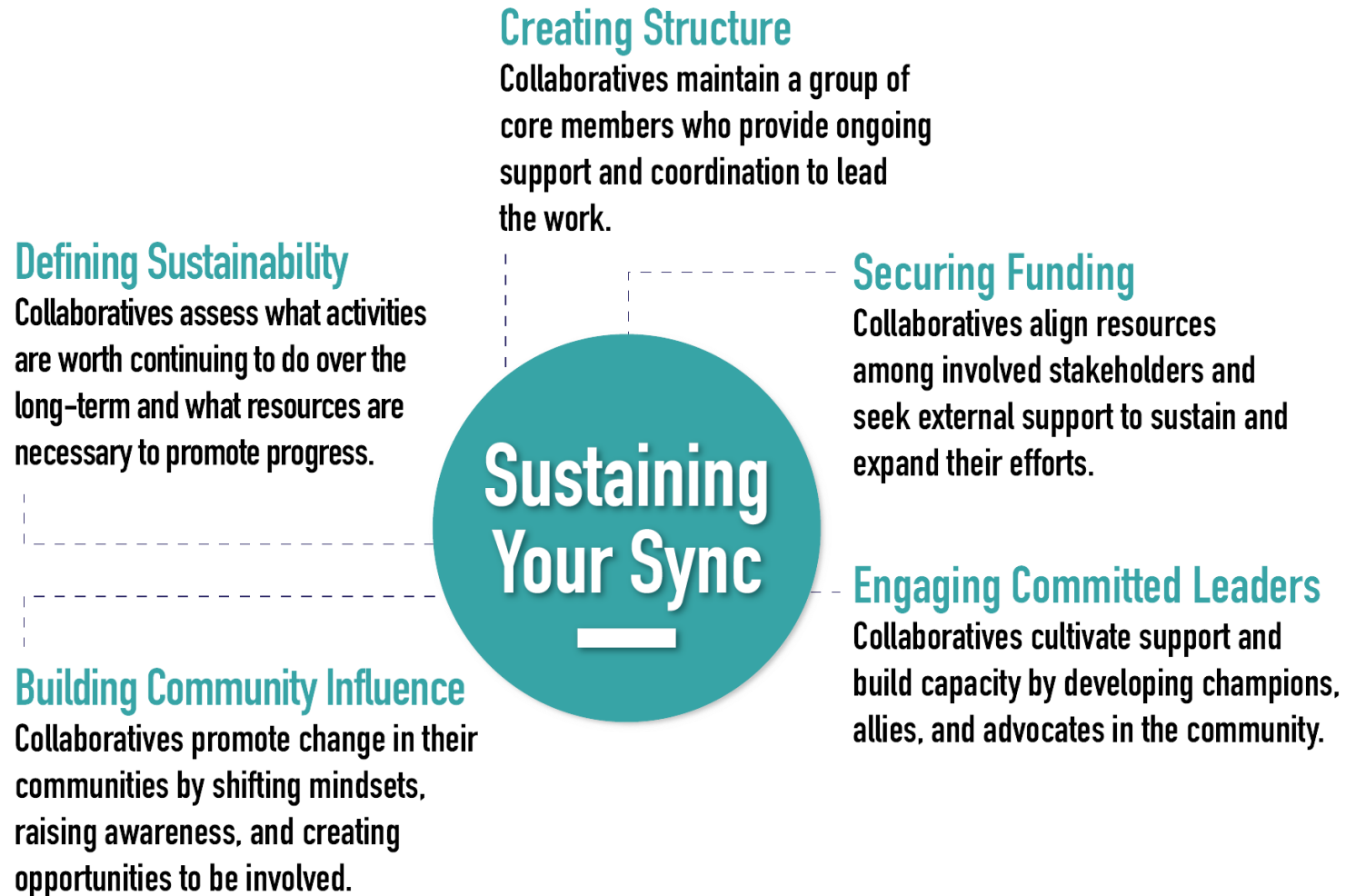
### PUT IT TO THE TEST — 4 minutes

Imagine all three measures improve. Would you feel confident telling the community you're making meaningful progress? If not, revisit your dashboard.

#### REPORT OUT

Share your three measures — and why you selected them.

## The Community Sync Framework — Sustaining Your Sync



## Keep the Momentum Going

Your collaborative has been working on the housing challenge for one year. Some things have changed:

- Several partners remain highly engaged
- The coordinator is leaving their organization
- Initial funding ends in six months

**YOUR CHALLENGE** — as a group, identify 3 actions you would take:

### Leadership

How will you address the loss of the coordinator?

### Resources

How will you prepare for the end of funding?

### Engagement

How will you keep partners invested?

### REPORT OUT

What would you do first — and why?

## PAST & CURRENT COHORTS

# ncIMPACT's Collaborative Programs

We apply the Community Sync Model to a range of critical issues.



### Opioid Response Project

Reducing stigma, increasing awareness, and improving access to treatment.



### myFutureNC LEACs

Increasing the number of students with post-secondary credentials.



### Our State, Our Work

Connecting Opportunity Youth to living-wage jobs.



### Our State, Our Wellbeing

Addressing mental health challenges and preventing suicides.



### Our State, Our Homes

Developing strategies for affordable housing.



### Our State, Our Future

Open to living-wage jobs, mental health, and affordable housing.

## READINESS CHECK

# When Is a Collaborative a Good Idea?

Use this checklist to determine if you are ready for the process.



**Is there consensus on the problem?**



**Is there general agreement on the reasons for the problem?**



**Are there committed, persistent leaders?**



**Does trust exist, or can it be built?**



**Is there human and financial capacity to coordinate the work?**



BENEFITS OF A SUCCESSFUL  
COLLABORATIVE

## Increased Awareness

---

Deeper understanding of the issue and local systems.

**EXAMPLE**

*“Huge reduction of stigma and a huge increase in awareness” for Opportunity Youth.*



BENEFITS OF A SUCCESSFUL  
COLLABORATIVE

## Shared Accountability & Risk

---

Fosters creativity and innovation across the collaborative.

**EXAMPLE**

*LEACs evaluated their structure and productivity against their goals.*



BENEFITS OF A SUCCESSFUL  
COLLABORATIVE

## Increased Capacity

---

Individual, organizational, and community-wide.

EXAMPLE

*Opioid Response Project participants reported “significantly higher levels of individual capacity.”*



BENEFITS OF A SUCCESSFUL  
COLLABORATIVE

## Resource Acquisition

---

**Collaboratives are more competitive for external grants and funding.**



## Supercharging the Process

**12–24 months of guidance, coaching, and expert connections.**



## Stakeholder Engagement

We help identify and sustain the right people at the table.

### EXAMPLE

*Ensuring employers' consistent engagement in LEACs.*



## Community Visibility & Legitimacy

Building public trust and buy-in.

### EXAMPLE

*CX100 helped teams make information “available and accessible.”*



## Evidence and Expertise

**We provide a menu of evidence-based strategies and help communities apply their own local expertise.**



## Infrastructure & Implementation

**Financial support for a program manager and a co-designed Shared Measurement System (SMS) for data-driven decisions.**

## CONCLUSION

# Cross-sector collaboratives offer real hope for tackling complex challenges.

- They require a common vision, a clear action plan, a shared measurement system, and a pathway to sustainability.
- This work is powerful — but not for the “faint of heart.”
- The ncIMPACT Community Sync Model provides a proven framework to guide communities toward collective success.

COMING THIS SPRING

# Spring Sync Course

Want hands-on guidance applying the Community Sync Model in your own community? Join us this spring.

DATE

[ to be announced ]

COST

[ to be announced ]

Details forthcoming — check [ncIMPACT.org](https://ncIMPACT.org) for updates.



# Questions?

[ncIMPACT.org](https://ncIMPACT.org) • [ncIMPACT@sog.unc.edu](mailto:ncIMPACT@sog.unc.edu)

**#ncIMPACT**

